

Chapter 10

Exercises

The term *exercise* is used among group leaders to refer to an activity that the group does for a specific purpose. An exercise can be as simple as having members get into dyads to discuss a topic or as involved as the "blind trust walk," which entails one member leading around a blindfolded member. Other examples of exercises include reading and discussing a poem, completing sentence stems, and drawing pictures of situations or feelings. In other words, *when the leader directs the behaviors, discussion, or attention of the group members by using a specific activity, it is an exercise.* In this chapter, we discuss the reasons for using exercises and the kinds of exercises available for use in groups. In Chapter 11, we discuss introducing, conducting, and processing exercises of all types.

According to Yalom (2005), structured exercises were first described for group work in the T-groups of the 1950s. Since then, the use of exercises in groups has been described in great detail by a number of authors. In fact, a number of books that contain nothing but group exercises have been written. With just a little effort, one can find books of group exercises on almost any subject for almost any population by searching the Internet or a source such as Amazon.com. Most experts now agree that group exercises can play an important role in making a group meaningful and interesting (Corey, 2012; Gladding, 2012; Yalom, 2005).

The exercises described in this and the following chapter come from a variety of sources. Some appeared initially in the excellent resource volumes of Pfeiffer and Jones (1972–1980). Others originated in Stevens's (1972) and Simon, Howe, and Kirschenbaum's (1978) work. Many of these exercises have been modified over time and passed along through workshops or by word of mouth. *It is important for the beginning leader to adapt exercises both to the needs of the group and to the age level, cultural background, and sophistication of the members.*



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS: How to Conduct Exercises Effectively

Go to video 10.1 and watch an introduction to exercises and a segment where the leader uses a creative exercise.

Reasons for Using Exercises

There are at least seven reasons for using exercises in a group:

1. To increase the comfort level
2. To provide the leader with useful information
3. To generate discussion and focus the group
4. To shift the focus
5. To deepen the focus
6. To provide an opportunity for experiential learning
7. To provide fun and relaxation

Exercises Help Increase the Comfort Level

Many members experience some degree of anxiety during the first couple of group sessions. Getting-acquainted exercises often increase comfort among members. The use of dyads can be helpful in increasing comfort during the early sessions and when preparing to discuss a very personal topic. Written exercises help with comfort because members often feel more comfortable reading what they wrote; that is they know they have something to say.

Exercises Provide the Leader with Useful Information

Exercises may be used to get information from the members. Rounds are often used in this way. For instance, the leader might ask members to use a single word to describe their home environment when they were growing up. In describing their home environment, members might use words such as *playful*, *warm*, *hostile*, *cold*, *competitive*, *abusive*, or *healthy*. By hearing how each member describes her early environment, the leader obtains information that can help her to focus the group. Another way to gather information about the home environment is to have members draw a family scene. An exercise where members talk about what kind of animal they would like to be can be very informative for the leader. Throughout this chapter, we discuss many more exercises that are useful in gaining information about the members.

Exercises Help Generate Discussion and Focus the Group

Using group exercises increases member participation by providing a common experience. Also, exercises serve as a way to stimulate members' interest and

energy. Some exercises can be helpful when dealing with members from different cultures because exercises can make concepts more visual and concrete. An exercise can be used to get members focused on a common issue or topic. For example, if the leader wanted to focus the group on the benefits of good study skills, he could say:

Leader: On a piece of paper, I'd like each of you to list three benefits of planning your study time.

Or if the leader wanted to focus the group on the topic of anger, she could use different lengths of cord to represent one's "anger fuse" and could say:

Leader: I want you to think about your anger and the length of your fuse. *(Points to all different sizes of cord from 1 to 12 inches)* Pick from the different fuses the fuse that best represents you in regards to anger—a short, medium, or long fuse.



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS: How to Conduct Exercises Effectively

View again video 7.1 where the leader uses fuses as an exercise.

Exercises Can Shift the Focus

A leader may want to use an exercise to shift the focus when he feels a new topic is needed. For example, if the leader wanted to shift from discussing anger at parents to feelings about themselves, he could say:

Leader: It seems like each of you has a wide variety of feelings of anger toward your parents. I hope our discussion here has given you some new ways to look at your relationship with them. Now I would like us to shift to a different topic—how you feel about yourself. I want you to think of three things that you like about yourself and three things you don't like about yourself.

Exercises Can Deepen the Focus

Exercises can be quite powerful and cause members to gain insights into themselves. Certain exercises can cause members to get more in touch with who they are and how they interact. Many feedback, trust, creative, fantasy, and movement exercises are designed to deepen the focus because members are asked to share or experience something at a more intense level.



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS: How to Conduct Exercises Effectively

Go to video 10.2 and watch an exercise where the leader uses a small chair to deepen the focus.

Exercises Provide an Opportunity for Experiential Learning

Exercises can also be used to provide an alternative approach to exploring issues other than through discussion. Sometimes it is helpful to get members to act out themes rather than just talk about them. For instance, let's say the group discussion centers around not being accepted by peers. To focus on this theme in a way other than through verbal sharing, the leader could have all members except one stand and gather in a tight circle with arms interlocked. The member outside the circle would then be instructed to attempt to break into the circle by whatever means possible while the members try to prevent the individual from entering. This exercise usually gets at feelings of loneliness and members' methods of attempting to gain the acceptance of others. Another experiential exercise is to have members pair up and experience the "pulls" on them as they try to reach their goals:

LEADER: This is an exercise about trying to reach your goals and feeling what keeps you from getting there. I want each of you to think about the goals that you hope to achieve in the next 2 to 5 years. (*Pause*) Now, I want you to pair up and then number off either 1 or 2. *(Members get into pairs and determine who is 1 and 2.)* Number 1, you will go first—face away from your partner, and extend your right arm back. Number 2, you take your partner's arm by the wrist with both your hands. On the count of three, Number 1, while thinking about your goals, you try to make progress; and Number 2, you offer some resistance. *(Leader demonstrates this with a member.)* The resistance may help you to get in touch with what is holding you back.

Exercises Provide Fun and Relaxation

Certain exercises can loosen up the group through laughter or relaxation. Using these kinds of exercises may be quite helpful when the group seems to need a change of pace and it is the kind of group where it would be appropriate. One fun exercise is called "pass the mask," where one member makes some kind of face at the next member and that member tries to make the same face back; then, the second member turns to the next member and makes a new face. The third member copies the mask and then creates a new one for the fourth member. This takes place rapidly and usually results in fun and laughter.

There are a number of relaxation exercises. A popular one calls for the leader to take a few minutes and go through a series of relaxation steps. The leader asks members to close their eyes and, starting with their heads, try to relax their muscles. They proceed to the neck, shoulders, and so on, until the entire body is relaxed. Another relaxation exercise is a group massage. In this exercise, one person lies on the floor and is massaged gently by all the other members. For some members this is a new experience because they have

experienced little or no touching. In our later discussion on touching exercises, we discuss the value of this exercise and offer caution about using such an exercise.

One common mistake of school counselors is that they spend too much time making the group fun and relaxing and not enough time making the experience meaningful. As one elementary counselor said, "I realize I have too much fluff in my groups." In summary, exercises may be used to increase interest and energy, generate a focus for the group, gather information, reduce anxiety, and have fun. In addition to these general uses, there are particular instances during any group where the leader may wish to use an exercise to accomplish a goal that is specific to what is happening in the group at the moment.

When to Use Exercises

Exercises can be used any time during a group session—at the very beginning, during the middle phase, and at the very end. Exercises can be very helpful to use in some groups at the very beginning because members are not focused on the task at hand. They may be nervous or they may be thinking about something that happened just before coming to the group or something that concerns them at work or at home. Exercises are very helpful during the middle or working phase for groups with members who need structured activities in order to focus. Most leaders use some simple exercises for closing a session, like a round of what was helpful or what members are going to do as a result of being in the session.

Kinds of Exercises

There are many kinds of exercises. We discuss 14 types in this chapter. Certain kinds of exercises will be more useful and relevant than others, depending on the kind of group you are leading; the issues to be dealt with; and the age, cultural background, and needs of the members. In some instances, these exercises are interchangeable in terms of their purpose and utility, but there are times when a certain kind of exercise is better than another. We discuss each kind in some detail:

- Written exercises
- Movement exercises
- Dyads and triads
- Rounds
- Creative props
- Arts and crafts exercises
- Fantasy exercises
- Common reading exercises
- Feedback exercises
- Trust exercises
- Experiential exercises
- Moral dilemma exercises
- Group-decision exercises
- Touching exercises

Written Exercises

Written exercises are among the most versatile and useful of all the exercise types. Written exercises are structured activities where members write lists, answer questions, fill in sentence-completion items, write down their reactions, or mark checklists relating to an issue or topic. The major advantages of written exercises are that members become focused while completing the writing task and members have their ideas or responses in front of them when they are finished. Drawing out members tends to be easier when they have answers or reactions readily available. Writing out responses eliminates the pressure of having to create responses on the spot.

Sentence-Completion Exercises One of the most useful types of written exercises is the sentence completion. A sentence completion is a written statement with a portion left blank for the member to fill in. Sentence completions generate interest and energy among members because members are usually curious about how other members have responded to the same sentence stems. Sentence completions can be devised for any topic or issue. For example, if the topic of discussion is divorce, the following sentence-completion exercise could be developed to help generate discussion:

Being divorced means _____.

The hardest thing about being divorced is _____.

Because of my divorce, when I think of future relationships, I _____ .

There are only three sentence stems here, but a leader can develop as many as he likes. Usually a leader does not want more than 5 or 6 sentence stems, although there may be times when as many as 10 are used. Also, a leader may use only one sentence stem to generate discussion for an entire session.

The following are three additional examples of helpful sentence-completion questionnaires. The first example is an excellent one to use in the beginning of many kinds of counseling, therapy, growth, and support groups. It could be used right after any introduction exercise or later in the first session. The questions give members a chance to share many thoughts and feelings about being in the group and about themselves. Also, the questions are worded so that the leader can use the responses to comment on how the group will be conducted and what will happen in the group.

When I enter a new group, I feel _____.

When people first meet me, they _____.

When I am in a new group, I feel most comfortable when _____.

When people remain silent, I feel _____.

I feel annoyed when the leader _____.

In a group, I am most afraid of _____.

The following sentence-completion form is intended to generate discussion about how individuals view themselves.

My greatest asset is _____.

I need to improve _____.

I regret _____.

My best accomplishment is _____.

Compared to others, I think I am _____.

I want most out of life to _____.

My biggest fear is _____.

I am _____.

This sentence-completion exercise can be used to focus discussion on members' thoughts and feelings about sex.

I think sex is _____.

Many of my feelings about sex come from _____.

Discussing sex in this group will be _____.

The sexual topic I would most like us to discuss would be _____.

Devising consistent sentence completions is very important. If you are devising your own sentence-completion forms, be sure that the sentences focus the members in the areas that you desire. For instance, in the third example above, the leader wants to focus on issues pertaining to sexual activity. An inappropriate sentence stem is "I enjoy being the sex I am because ___." It is inappropriate because it would generate discussion about gender and sex roles rather than sex and sexual behavior.

Listing Exercises Having members make a list is another very useful written exercise. Lists can be done quickly and can easily be geared to the level and needs of the group members. Some examples of lists include: characteristics of friendship; hobbies, and other recreational activities; important people; positive personal qualities; traits desired in a love partner; or characteristics inherent in the ideal job. Making a list is useful to members because it allows them to summarize their thoughts in a succinct fashion; it also helps them to focus. Once the list is complete, it can be used in a variety of ways. The leader can ask members to share a portion or the entire list, or have members share lists in dyads or triads. For example, in an education/growth group about stress, the leader may ask members to list things that are stressful to them. Once the members have done so, the leader could ask them to get into triads and discuss their lists, starting first with work stressors, then home stressors, and then other stressors.

Written-Response Exercises The third type of written exercise is called a *response* exercise, because the leader asks members to respond in various ways to problems or questions posed by the leader. The following are examples:

- Members write their own epitaph or obituary.
- Members write short responses to questions such as, What is the role of a school counselor? or How does having children change one's life?

- Members complete multiple-choice questions, state preferences, or give one-word answers to different questions.
- Members write reaction papers after viewing movies or TV shows or reading books or poems.

For example, knowing that a certain movie will be on TV, the leader might ask the members to watch it and write a personal reaction reflecting what the movie meant to them. The members then bring their reactions to the group. In each case, members have their reactions or answers in front of them when the leader asks them to share their responses.

Diaries A fourth type of written exercise uses diaries either during the session or at home. Within a session, members write personal reactions to what has taken place in that session. Often this is done at the end of the session; the leader allots the last 5 or 10 minutes for members to write.

LEADER: We're now finished except for writing in your diary. As I explained last week, this is time for you to write any thoughts, feelings, or reactions that you have had during the session. Take as much time as you'd like to write. Also, remember that your diary will be a good summary of the group and may be something you will want to read years from now.

The diaries are usually left for the leader to read; this gives her both immediate feedback about the session and the opportunity to write comments in the diaries. The leader gets an idea of what the members are gaining from the group and what might need to be addressed in future sessions. We have found that some members write things that they would not say in the group. Also, leaving the diaries enables the leader to write back to the members. (The members usually read their diaries at the beginning of the next session.) Written comments can be encouraging statements, clarifying comments, or suggestions regarding how the member may use the group experience. Riordan and White (1996) found that 9 out of 10 members report feeling favorable toward the practice of writing in a diary.

If the leader feels that members will not respond honestly or deeply because they know he will read the diaries, he may choose not to have members turn them in. The obvious disadvantage to this is that the leader does not get to read what the members are saying about the group experience.

Diaries can also be used at home. Members take their diaries home and write their reactions to the group or to anything that happens to them during the week that is relevant. These journals or diaries would periodically be given to the leader. Reading the diaries helps the leader know what is helpful in the group and also how members are reacting to and feeling about things that happen to them during the week. An advantage of jotting down thoughts or events throughout the week is that members focus on themselves at different times during the week and not just during the hour or two each week that the group meets. Writing also helps members remember what happened to them so they can report these happenings to the group. With the member's permission,

comments from a diary may also be shared with other members if the leader feels something has been mentioned that would be helpful to the whole group.

Movement Exercises

Movement exercises require members to do something of a physical nature; that is, the members move around. The movements can be as simple as standing up and moving about in order to stretch or as complex as "breaking in," an exercise in which members, standing and holding hands, try to keep a member who is circling the group from breaking in. Many examples of movement exercises are described next.

Changing Seats This exercise involves members standing and then finding a different seat in which to sit. The purpose is to allow members to stretch and move around and also to sit next to and face different members by virtue of changing location. The leader might introduce this exercise by saying:

LEADER: I'd like you to stand up and take a minute to stretch; then find a seat other than the one you had. Try to seat yourselves by members you have not sat next to.

Milling Around This exercise involves having the members walk around. There are a number of activities that the members may do while milling, such as experiencing or avoiding eye contact or touching another member gently on the shoulder or elbow. The specifics of what to do while milling depend on the purpose of the exercise. The milling would last for no more than 3 minutes. To begin, the leader might say the following:

LEADER: I want you to stand up. *(Members stand.)* We are going to do a non-verbal milling exercise. The first thing I want you to do is to move about the room with your head down, avoiding eye contact with anyone. *(Members do this for about 1 minute.)* Now I want you to mill around, but this time make eye contact for as long you desire.

This exercise gets members in touch with their comfort level with others. It can be used in groups that are exploring their feelings about interacting with others.

Values Continuum With this exercise, members position themselves according to how they think and feel about an issue. The leader designates certain locations in the room as symbolic of a viewpoint. One side of the room represents one point of view, and the other side the opposite point of view. The members are asked to stand in the middle of the room and then move to the position on the continuum between the two designated spots.

LEADER: I want everyone to stand up and line up here in the middle of the room behind Jim. *(Allows members to do this.)* Okay, now on the count of 3, I am going to ask you to position yourself where you feel you are on the continuum that I am about to describe. The continuum is from the wall on your right, which will be "high risk taker," to the wall on

your left, which will be "play it very safe." *(Pause)* Everyone understand? Okay—on 3, position yourselves. Ready? 1, 2, 3.

The benefit of having members walk to a designated area is that all the members have to declare their position at the same time and everyone can visually see how others feel about a given issue. It also offers a change in the format; instead of stating their position, this exercise gives members the opportunity to move and to view others' positions. Also, everyone is communicating, they are just doing it nonverbally with their feet. Possible continuums include the following:

saver _____ spender
winner _____ loser
happy _____ unhappy
interesting person _____ boring person
life is hard _____ life is easy
easy to trust _____ hard to trust
like school _____ hate school



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS: Movement Exercises

Review video 8.7 for a demonstration in which the leader uses a value continuum to focus on the issue of liking school.

Goals Walk In this exercise, the members line up across from each other. Each member will take a turn walking through the area between the members. The members act as obstacles in the walker's path toward his or her goals, which are at the other end.

LEADER: I want everyone to stand up and make two lines with three on one side and four on the other. Stand a few feet apart, making sort of a path. What we are going to do is have each of you walk down the path. Let me have a volunteer. *(Hilda volunteers and steps to the front of the group, where the leader is standing.)* Hilda, in a minute, you're going to walk through the group. I'd like you to look down the path and envision reaching your goals and life being fairly smooth as being at the other end. Okay, now I want you to think of your goals and then tell us how difficult you perceive it will be to reach those goals. If you see it as hard at first, then, Jane, you and Sandy will want to sort of block her and make it hard because you are in front here. If it is going to be hard in the middle, then Kevin and Karen will make it hard. I know some of you have some pretty tough things ahead of you. What we want to do is give each person a chance to experience physically some of the bumps in the path toward his or her goals. You'll make it hard

by blocking, holding, or whatever, but it is important to not make it impossible and also not to laugh because that will take away from the person's experience. Okay, Hilda, tell us how you see the path ahead.

If done right, this exercise can be very thought provoking. If members know each other well, certain members in the line can play certain characters in the person's life, such as drinking buddies, old lover, ex-spouse, mother, or the "bottle." The leader has to pay close attention to make sure it does not get too physical or turn into a joking kind of activity. We have used this in many different ways and found it to have great impact.

How Far Have You Come? In this exercise, the leader has the members stand side by side and think about how far they have come during the group in terms of reaching their goals.

LEADER: I think this exercise can be of help in getting you to see where you are in the group. Everyone stand up and line up next to each other. *(The leader stands about 8 feet away.)* If the imaginary line that I'm drawing represents your reaching the goals that we talked about in our first session, how far have you come toward reaching them? Some of you have come pretty far; others, not so far, but I want each of you to position yourself in terms of your progress. On 3—*(Pause)* 1, 2, 3.

After people position themselves, there can be much discussion. The leader can also have them put one foot forward, symbolizing a step toward their goal, and have each person talk about what the next step could be.

Sculpt Your Feeling About the Group This is an exercise where the leader has the members stand in a circle and "sculpt" how they feel about the group, using their body and hands.

LEADER: I want everyone to stand and make a large circle. In a minute, I am going to ask you to indicate how you are feeling about this group by using your body language and position. If you are really into the group and open for it, you would come to the center and have your arms open. If you are against the group, you would turn your back to the group and have your arms closed around you. You can use your body, your arms, your hands, anything to express exactly how you are feeling about the group. Everyone understand? *(Pause)* Okay, on 3—1, 2, 3.

This is an excellent exercise if the group is not going well and the leader believes it has some potential. The exercise should lead to a discussion about the group.



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS: Movement Exercises

Go to video 10.4 for a demonstration in which the leader uses this sculpturing exercise.

Family Sculpture Similar to having members sculpt how they feel about the group, in this exercise, the leader has members sculpt their families as they see them now or when they were growing up. This exercise is usually very revealing. Members find it interesting to sculpt their own family and to see how other members sculpt theirs. The exercise is used to generate discussion about past and present family relationships.

EXAMPLE

The group is composed of male teenagers.

LEADER: Today we are going to focus on our families. To do this, we are going to do an exercise called *family sculpture*. What this entails is that each of you will sculpt your family by picking other members to play your parents or the adults you live with, your siblings, and any other significant person in your family and positioning them to show how they relate to one another. For example, the parents may be holding hands or they may be far apart with their fists raised. The kids may be close together or very far apart. Some may be close to Dad but not Mom, or they may even have their backs to their parents. Who will volunteer to go first? I'll explain more as you go along.

TONY: I will. What do I do?

LEADER: Stand here in the center. Who lives at home with you?

TONY: My mom, my dad, and my little sister.

LEADER: Pick a member to be each one of these, and pick someone to be you.

TONY: Bob, you be my dad. Sam, you be me. Don, I guess you will have to be my mom, and Bill, you be my sister.

LEADER: Now position these people as you see them. Are your mom and dad close?

TONY: No, they hardly speak. They would be at the opposite ends of the room. Can I put them there?

LEADER: Sure. Where would you put you and your sister?

TONY: My sister is real close to my mom, so I would put her over there with her. I am not close to anyone, so I would be way over in the other corner away from everyone. Gee, this is heavy!

The leader usually spends 2 or 3 minutes discussing the sculpture as each member designs it. When everyone has had a turn, a long discussion usually takes place on family issues.

Group Sculpture Similar to family sculpture, group sculpture is an exercise that has the members sculpt how they see the group. This is different from the sculpture where members sculpt themselves. In this exercise, a member sculpts everyone; that is, members position people in the group in accordance to how

they see the different relationships and roles of the members. This can be a good exercise for groups where members know each other well, such as in a residential group or a long-term counseling or therapy group. It serves as a feedback exercise because members show how they see the different members of the group.

Home Spot In this exercise, members stand in a circle holding hands. Each one picks a spot in the room to try to maneuver the group toward it. Because most members have a different spot and all are holding hands, many different dynamics occur.

LEADER: Let's try something different. We've been discussing how many of you do not always go after what you want and need. There is an exercise that I think you'll find interesting. I want you to stand up and move your chairs all the way against the wall. *(Members do this.)* Now come to the center and form a circle, holding hands. Not too tight a circle. Now I'd like each of you to look around and pick a spot in the room. In a minute, I am going to ask you, while still holding hands, to try to move to that spot. This is to be done without any talking or laughter. Your main goal is to get to your spot, without letting go of the other members' hands. Get ready. Okay, try to move to your spot.

Members will pull, push, give up, kneel on the floor, and so on. The leader will stop the exercise after a minute or so and then process the various reactions. The purpose of the exercise is to focus members on how hard they try to get what they want.

Personal Space This exercise consists of members standing in a circle not too close to each other—almost at arm's length. The leader then instructs them to close their eyes and to feel the space around them, exploring around their head and in front, to the sides, and behind them. The leader then instructs them to venture out of "their space" by using their arms, which usually results in members touching each other. Discussion often centers on the comfort level of their space and feelings about venturing out. Eventually, the leader will want the discussion to move toward members' feelings about their space as they live their daily lives.

Become a Statue This exercise requires members to stand at some distance from each other; on the count of three they all become statues to show how they see themselves, either in the group or in their lives outside the group (depending on the purpose of the exercise). This exercise is good for giving members the chance to visually represent themselves.

Trust There are a number of trust exercises that involve movement. These are discussed later in this chapter in the section titled "Trust Exercises."

Reasons for Using Movement Exercises There are at least five good reasons for using movement exercises.

- Movement exercises give group members a chance to *experience* something rather than discuss it.
- The drama of movement exercises may cause members to remember what took place in the group more readily in the days or weeks following than might otherwise occur if only discussion is used.
- Movement exercises usually involve all the members. That is, all members are up and doing something, whereas in discussion exercises some members may not be involved.
- Movement exercises give members a chance to stretch and move around. This can be good for young people and for members who have been sitting for a long while. It is important to remember that members can become bored and fatigued if seated too long or if the format remains unchanged for extended periods.
- Most movement exercises usually get the members to "talk" with their feet, such as when they position themselves on a continuum. Therefore, leaders can draw members out by having them do some kind of movement and then asking them to comment on why they positioned themselves as they did.

Cautions When Using Movement Exercises Various situations and client populations may not be conducive to using movement activities. Leaders should not attempt strenuous movement activities with the elderly or people with significant health problems. Any time the exercise calls for vigorous movement, make sure objects such as chairs, desks, or tables are well out of the way. Also make sure that members remove eyeglasses or any other items that may be damaged or that may injure others. It is important to recognize that some movement exercises involve touching and some members do not want to be touched by other members.

Dyads and Triads

Dyads give members a chance to (1) interact with one other individual, (2) practice some skill, or (3) do an activity that calls for two people to interact in some prescribed manner. We discussed the use of dyads extensively in Chapter 9, but we did not discuss the use of dyads as a specific exercise, as in the following.

One exercise is called "I Have To—I Choose To." In this exercise, members pair up and take turns saying aloud their list of things that they feel they "have" to do. Then they go back and change the recitation from "I have to" to "I choose to." A variation of this is to start with the phrase "I need," which changes to "I want." These kinds of exercises give members a chance to hear how they can change some of their demands or needs. Saying statements aloud to another person makes more of an impact than saying them only to oneself.

Another dyad exercise is one in which a member says to the partner, "I should ..." and the partner firmly responds, "No, you shouldn't!" Each partner goes through his list of "shoulds" and experiences being told no. This exercise helps members think through what really are important "shoulds" in their lives.

Another dyad or triad exercise that can prove to be very enlightening is to have members pair up and have each assume the role of one of her parents. Then the "parents" talk about their son or daughter. This exercise can help members experience how they perceive their parents' opinions of them and is a valuable exercise for all age groups. Stevens (1972) calls this exercise "parents' chat."

Rounds

As we said in Chapter 9, rounds are probably the most valuable exercises available to a leader. One kind of round not mentioned in Chapter 9 is the forced-choice round. This consists of the leader reading a statement and the members stating how they feel about the statement. The members would usually respond with *strongly agree, agree, disagree,* or *strongly disagree*. The following are some examples of statements that could be used:

- Extramarital affairs are always harmful.
- Divorce means failure.
- A person's personal worth is always changing.
- Physical attractiveness is very important.
- One should love one's parents no matter what.

As you can see, responses to these kinds of sentences have the potential to generate a lot of discussion. The leader's skill comes in choosing appropriate statements. Forced-choice sentences can serve as an effective way to stimulate interaction in a group.

Exercises Using Creative Props

Impact Therapy: The Courage to Counsel (Jacobs & Schimmel, 2013) emphasizes making counseling multisensory and concrete. The use of different counseling props is a way to make group counseling more multisensory, interesting, and engaging. Items such as rubber bands, Styrofoam cups, a small child's chair, and an empty beer bottle all can be used in groups. The following group exercises show how leaders can use props effectively.

Rubber Bands

EXAMPLES

Leader: I want each of you to take one of these thick rubber bands *(One that stretches over a foot.)* and stretch it until you feel the tension. Hold your hands out and experience the stress. Because this group is on stress management, I thought that rubber bands may help you to see how you are doing dealing with your own stress. Since our meeting last week, has your stress increased or decreased? I want you to either increase the tension or loosen it. Also, think about ways you can reduce

your stress and note that for the tension on the rubber band to decrease, you have to do something! Think about this for a minute, and then I'll ask you to share your feelings and thoughts.

■ ■ ■

LEADER: This is now the third meeting of our couples' group, so I thought we would take a look at the tension you have in your relationship. I want each of you to get with your partner and take a rubber band. *(Some playfully act as though they are going to "pop" their partners.)* I see some of you already are kind of acting out parts of your marriage. I want you to think about how you can use the rubber band in various ways to symbolize your relationship and interactions. I'll give you about 2 minutes to work with your partner and the rubber band. *(Members work together for a few minutes.)*

JANE: We pulled until it nearly broke and then we sort of looked at each other. Neither one of us gave in, though, so here we sit with the tension at its maximum.

ETO: Ours was very different. We played with it, and then we each popped each other sort of hard.

■ ■ ■

Styrofoam Cups

■ EXAMPLES

LEADER: I want each of you to take a cup and a pencil. I want you to think of the cup as representing your personal worth, and then I want you to punch holes in the cup as you think about the things that cause you not to like yourself. A hole may represent your appearance, not having friends, your parents' reactions to you, your intelligence, or anything else you can think of. When you are done, each of you will get a chance to share your cup. Some of you may have some holes that you don't want to share yet with the group and you can just say something like, "There are two more big ones that I am not ready to share yet." The point of the holes is to help you see what you may want to work on in the group.



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS: Creative Exercises

View video 10.1 again for a demonstration in which the leader uses Styrofoam cups. See how the leader uses the holes in the cup to get members to share more deeply about themselves.

■ ■ ■

LEADER: I want everyone to look at this cup I am holding and think of it as your own self-worth. *(The leader now stands on a chair.)* As I stand and start to squeeze the cup, I want you to decide to whom you give your worth—the person you have on the chair that you allow to hurt or squeeze you. *(Everyone looks up and seems to be in deep thought.)* Any comments or reactions?

■ ■ ■

Small Chair

■ EXAMPLE

LEADER: We have been talking about having fun, so I want you to focus on the idea of having fun. To help you, I want you to look at this small chair and think about the fun little boy or girl inside you. I want you to think about what happened to him or her as you have grown up. Because many of you said you don't have fun, we need to hear from the child part of you. *(All stare intensely at the chair. A couple of members start to cry.)*

CATHY: This is very powerful for me. I stopped having fun when I was 14 because of something that happened. *(Cries)*

MATT: I used to have fun, but when my mom died, I felt that I had to help out, and I have been doing that ever since.

LEADER: What about others of you? Our goal is to get you to have fun—to listen to that part of you that wants to enjoy life.

■ ■ ■



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS: Creative Exercises

View video 10.2 again for a demonstration in which the leader uses the small chair to focus on when members feel like a little girl or boy. Note the power of having the small chair present.

Beer Bottle

■ EXAMPLE

LEADER: I want each of you to look at this beer bottle and this string. I want you to let the string represent either your life, your ability to control your mood, or your tolerance for not getting angry. Now watch what happens to the long string as I put it into the bottle. What do you see?

CARLOS: It gets shorter.

DOTTIE: It gets gobbled up. Disappears.

LEADER: Now, what do you take this to mean for you? *(The leader places the bottle in the center of the group. Everyone stares at it.)*

These are just some of the props a leader can use to focus the group on a topic. Some other useful props are shields, playing cards, and furnace filters (Jacobs and Schimmel, 2013).

Arts and Crafts Exercises

Arts and crafts exercises require that members draw, cut, paste, paint, or create something with a variety of materials. These exercises can generate interest, focus the group, create energy, and trigger discussion. Arts and crafts exercises allow members to express themselves in a different way; that is, members can put their thoughts and feelings into a project before they share verbally with others. This activity is especially helpful for members who have difficulty identifying or expressing feelings directly. For this reason, arts and crafts exercises are useful with younger children, but they are also useful for all ages. Having members draw their dream house or their imaginary coat of arms can stimulate very interesting discussions.

One example of an arts and crafts exercise involves the use of paper bags, magazines, scissors, and tape or glue. All these materials are passed out to each member. Members are then told to look through their magazines and cut out any word, phrase, or picture that describes them right now. Those aspects they are willing to share with the group are to be pasted on the outside of the bag. Those they are not willing to share are placed inside the bag. When it comes time for discussion, members hold up their bags and tell the group about themselves. This exercise is particularly useful in helping members become acquainted with each other, and it makes sharing easier. The leader can also choose to focus on what is in the bag by discussing why people tend not to want to share parts of themselves.

A second reason for using arts and crafts exercises is they can serve as projective devices for the members' thoughts, feelings, and experiences. That is, current problems may be represented in a creative project. For example, the leader might ask members to draw a picture of themselves and their family engaging in a typical interaction. Often, much is revealed by such drawings.

A third benefit of arts and crafts exercises is that members seem to enjoy seeing what other members have drawn, painted, or built. Thus, sharing oneself and listening to others becomes more interesting when members can see what is being talked about.

Another reason for using arts and crafts exercises is that they are nonverbal and may be helpful in groups where language is a problem. We encourage leaders who have members from many different cultures to consider these kinds of

exercises if they are finding it difficult to get members involved in other kinds of exercises. One note of cautions for school counselors; school groups are often very limited in the amount of time that is available. Therefore, school counselors who choose to use arts and crafts exercises should pay particular attention to the time requirements of such exercises and sometimes allow for additional sessions for processing arts and crafts exercises.

Fantasy Exercises

Fantasy exercises are most often used in growth and therapy groups. Fantasies help members become more aware of their feelings, wishes, doubts, and fears. An example of a fantasy exercise is the "common object," in which the leader directs the members to imagine themselves as an object that is in the room (a book, wastebasket, cup, purse, window, pencil, chair, and so forth). The leader guides the members through the fantasy by asking what it feels like to be the object, what life is like being that object, their role in life, and so forth.

EXAMPLES

LEADER: *(Very slowly and softly)* I want you to look at this briefcase, and I want you to become this briefcase. Think about what your life is like as a briefcase. How does it feel? *(Pause)* What happens to you as a briefcase? *(Pause)* What is it like being a briefcase? *(Pause)* In a few seconds, I am going to ask you to share your experience of being a briefcase. I would like you to start by saying, "I am a briefcase, and as a briefcase...."

■ ■ ■

LEADER: I want each of you to close your eyes and get comfortable. *(Pause)* *(Using a soothing voice with a slow pace)* Now I want you to imagine that you are a tree. *(Pause)* What kind of tree are you? *(Pause)* What are your surroundings? *(Pause)* What is life like as a tree? *(Pause)* How does it feel being the tree that you are? *(Pause)* Okay, who wants to go first and share what he or she experienced?

■ ■ ■

Other examples of fantasy exercises include a movie fantasy (members imagine that they are watching a movie of their lives and they think of the title, producer and director, main characters, and audience reactions); the hot-air balloon fantasy (members imagine they are in a hot-air balloon trying to lift off but are weighted down by various weights in their lives); the "wise man" fantasy (members imagine taking a trip up a mountain to visit an old wise man to get an answer to an important question); and the funeral fantasy (members imagine their own funeral and the reactions of people attending it).

When members discuss their fantasies, the leader encourages them to determine if the feelings attributed to the object or fantasy do, in fact, apply to their

daily lives. Because certain kinds of fantasy exercises may cause members to explore thoughts and feelings that have been denied to their conscious awareness, leaders who use fantasy exercises should be prepared for members to get in touch with some painful material.

Common Reading Exercises

In common reading exercises members read a short passage, poem, or story. Such readings often serve the purpose of triggering ideas and thoughts and of deepening the focus on some topic or issue. For example, in growth groups, the "Gestalt prayer" (Perls, 1969) may serve as a stimulating common reading:

> I do my thing, and you do your thing.
> I am not in this world to live up to your expectations
> And you are not in this world to live up to mine.
> You are you and I am I,
> And if by chance we find each other, it's beautiful.
> If not, it can't be helped.

Although members have a variety of reactions to this passage, it usually triggers discussion about demands and expectations placed on others as well as the need for approval and acceptance. Other passages and poems that have proven effective have come from *The Prophet* by Kahlil Gibran or poems by T. S. Eliot. The following example comes from Robert Frost's poem "The Road Not Taken."

> Two roads diverged in a wood, and I—
> I took the one less traveled by,
> And that has made all the difference.

This is a very inspiring passage and often gives members permission to be different and not follow the crowd. As members read the passage, they are reminded of incidents in their own lives concerning choices they have made. Some may have taken the less-traveled road, while others did not. Usually a good discussion follows the reading of this passage.

The key factor to keep in mind when using common reading exercises is the purpose of the group. Make sure that the material will trigger thoughts related to the purpose. Also, consider the intellectual capabilities of the members when asking them to read and react to a poem or written verse. Obviously, the preceding examples would not be appropriate for elementary school children. There are interesting materials written for all educational levels.



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS: Creative Exercises

Go to video 10.3 for a demonstration in which the leader uses a common reading.

Feedback Exercises

One potential benefit of being in groups is the opportunity to hear what others think of you. Listed here are a number of feedback exercises that may be valuable to members. Feedback exercises allow the members and the leader to share their feelings and thoughts about each other. Leaders should not conduct a feedback exercise unless they feel the members have enough goodwill to try to be helpful rather than cruel or insensitive. It is best to avoid conducting a feedback exercise with members who have no desire to be helpful or to listen to feedback from others.

First Impressions This is an exercise where members share their first impressions of other members. This can be done in the first session or can be used in later sessions when the members have had a chance to revise their first impressions. If used in a later session, members get a chance to hear how they are perceived now and how they were perceived when others first met them.

Adjective Checklist Members take turns being the focus of the group. Members are given a written list of 15 to 20 adjectives that describe people, and members pick 3 to 5 adjectives that describe the member who is receiving feedback. Using the adjectives gives members a structured way to describe each other.

Talk About the Members There will be times when the leader will decide to focus on a member for the purpose of giving her feedback. The leader would have members talk about the member, focusing on whatever the leader thinks would be helpful, such as how she presents herself, issues she is avoiding, or positive qualities. When doing this, the leader may have the member being discussed sit quietly and close her eyes, or turn around so she is not facing the group. This depends on the member receiving feedback, the members giving the feedback, and the kind of feedback that is about to be given. If the leader feels the members will speak more openly if the member who is receiving feedback is not watching, the leader may have that member turn around. Also, many people have said they can listen better when they are not looking at others while they are being talked about. The leader should use caution when conducting this type of exercise and should do this only when it is helpful for the member receiving the feedback.

Strength Bombardment This exercise is similar to the preceding one because the members talk about each other; but in this exercise, the feedback is done in a more organized fashion. That is, the leader directs the group to describe the strengths of the designated member. The leader appoints one member to keep a list of all the strengths so that the member can have the list when the exercise is over. A variation is to also list weaknesses or areas needing improvement.

Wishes A nonthreatening way to give feedback is by using wishes. The leader sets this exercise up by asking members to verbalize any wishes that they have for a given member.

LEADER: What I would like you to do is think of wishes that you have for various members. We'll focus on one person at a time, and anyone who has a wish for that person will say, "My wish for you is...."

This is a good exercise for members who are concerned for each other and who have various things to say to each other. It is a good exercise for support groups and for some growth, counseling, and therapy groups.



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS: My Wish for You

Go to video 15.2 for a demonstration in which the leader uses a "my wish for you" exercise in her closing of the group.

Metaphorical Feedback The leader asks members to think of an animal, a character in the movies or on TV, or an inanimate object, such as a sunset or a babbling brook, that reminds them of a designated member. Each member gets to hear how others see him, but the feedback comes in metaphorical fashion.

Written Feedback In this exercise, members are asked to write out feedback for each member of the group. This is usually done between sessions because it can take quite a bit of time. The value of this kind of feedback is that members experience reading about themselves from the point of view of a number of other people. Most people have not received written feedback from six or eight people at one time. This kind of feedback activity should be used only with members who are basically stable and members who have been meeting for quite a while. The leader would provide members with instructions on what kind of feedback to write.

Most/Least Feedback This kind of feedback involves members sharing how they feel about other members by using a "most" and "least" designation. For example, the leader may ask members to designate the following:

- To whom they feel most similar and least similar
- With whom they feel most comfortable and least comfortable
- Whom they trust most and whom they trust least
- Who they feel is working hardest in the group and who they feel is working the least

This kind of exercise can create much interaction and must be used with care. The leader can ask for just one category, such as "most comfortable," instead of both categories. Members not only give feedback, but receive feedback by being named by others. After the initial round of members offering their views, members should be allowed to ask questions about why they were named by another member.

These are just some of the feedback exercises that are possible. Different kinds of feedback exercises elicit different kinds of responses. The important

things to remember when deciding to focus the group on feedback are the level of trust and goodwill of the members and the purpose of the group.

Trust Exercises

Because groups involve sharing, *the amount of trust that members have in each other is a group dynamic the leader must assess.* If the leader finds that members do not trust one another or that more trust seems to be needed in the group, he may choose to have the members participate in trust exercises. Each of the following exercises is intended to focus members on the issue of trust.

Rounds Listed are some examples of rounds that can be used to initiate a discussion of trust:

- On a 1–10 scale, with 10 being a person who can trust others easily and 1 being someone for whom it is difficult to trust, how would you rate yourself?
- In this group, do you feel that there is a lot of trust, moderate trust, or little trust? I want you to think how you would respond to that question, and we will go around the group and hear from each of you.
- When you were growing up, would you say your environment was very trusting, moderately trusting, or not trusting at all?

In each of these rounds, the issue of trust is the focus. The first two could relate directly to the group, whereas the last one would reflect what members learned about trusting at an early age. Certainly some of what they learned is probably affecting them in the group.

Trust Lift In this exercise, members stand in a tight circle with one person in the center. The members gently move that person around by the shoulders for about a minute. During this time, the member's eyes are closed, his feet are stationary if possible, and everyone is silent. Then, the members gently take the person by the feet, waist, shoulders, and head and gradually lift him over their heads. Then they slowly rock the person while bringing him gently to the floor. A member willing to do this would be trusting the group not to drop him. The leader should focus discussion both on being lifted and on being responsible for lifting.

The obvious caution for this exercise is that the members must be capable of lifting the person. Also, the leader should be prepared for one or two members to choose not to participate because of their fear of being dropped or perhaps even of being touched. During this exercise, the leader must make sure that someone holds the person's head and neck to ensure comfort.

Trust Fall The trust fall exercise is done in pairs or threes. It consists of one person standing, with one or two members right behind her. The person in front falls backward, and the others catch her at a safe distance above the floor. The cautions mentioned in the trust lift also apply to this exercise. This exercise should not be done on hard surfaces, such as tile or concrete.

Blind Trust Walk This exercise is done in pairs, with one person blindfolded and the other serving as a guide. During the exercise, there should be no talking except for directions, such as "step down." The purpose of the exercise is for members to experience trusting another person to lead them. When doing this exercise, the leader would want to be in a setting that would accommodate members walking around without interference. It will probably not work in an agency or school unless there is a very large room or it is after hours. Each member should be led around for about 5 minutes to get the effect; ideally, the walk should be such that the blindfolded member experiences more than walking around in a circle. That is, it is good to have members maneuver around doors, chairs, steps, tables, and so on. In addition, during the processing of this exercise, most of the time should be spent discussing trust, although some time will be spent on discussing the experience of the walk.

Experiential Exercises

Several group exercises can be classified as experiential because the members are involved in some kind of individual or group experience that is active and often challenging. Some experiential exercises can also be used to build trust. Probably the most well-known set of experiential exercises is the "Ropes Course," which is "a blend of activities designed to take individuals and groups beyond their own expectations, or perceived willingness to try" (Rohnke & Tait, 2007). The activities are done outdoors on a carefully designed course made up of ropes. Some of the activities are very challenging and seem dangerous, which force individuals to come face to face with themselves (Rohnke & Tait, 2007). Other activities on the ropes course depend on members cooperating with each other; thus, it is good for team building. Some group leaders use the ropes course as one part of their group, whereas other leaders just lead groups through the ropes course or some other kind of experiential activity.

When thinking about experiential exercises, it is important to make sure that the exercise fits the purpose. There are many outdoor activities that are fun and interesting, but they may not be appropriate for the group you are leading. If an experiential component fits with your purpose, it is a good idea to consider using experiential activities because they are interesting and give your members a very different experience.

Moral Dilemma Exercises

Several group exercises can be considered "moral dilemmas"; that is, a story is read or passed out to the members and each member has to decide how she would handle the situation. Some of these stories involve stealing food to sustain life, deciding who is allowed to stay in a lifeboat, or deciding whether to tell the authorities about a crime. Simon, Howe, and Kirschenbaum (1978) describe one involving a fallout shelter and who is let in. Probably the most popular moral dilemma exercise is called "Alligator River." It is a story about a woman needing to cross a river to obtain a lifesaving medicine. She must decide whether to give

in to the demands of the riverboat captain in order to get across. You may choose to use these exercises or invent your own. Moral dilemma exercises have been found to be very helpful in facilitating discussion among adolescents.

■ EXAMPLE

LEADER: You are on a ship when it wrecks. Seven people want to get into the life raft, and it holds only five. The people are you, a 12-year-old hoodlum-type kid, a 52-year-old retired teacher, a 30-year-old star baseball player, a 22-year-old auto mechanic, a 62-year-old preacher, and a pregnant, 39-year-old homemaker. Who would you think should *not* be allowed on the life raft?

■ ■ ■

These exercises usually generate a discussion about values, justice, and fairness. They can be used at the beginning of a session and become the focus of the entire session, or they can be used as an exercise that takes about 30 minutes to discuss and process.

Group-Decision Exercises

These activities involve members working together to solve some sort of problem, such as being lost on the moon with certain supplies. The group would be asked to determine the best way to use the supplies. Depending on the size of the group, the entire group may work together as one unit or be divided into two or three groups of four members each. Another activity calls for sharing resources such as rulers, scissors, tape, paper, string, and pencils to complete a project. This one would usually be done nonverbally. Members would be given different resources and a task to complete; they would be told that they can share or do anything they like except talk in order to complete the task. It would either be stated or would quickly become apparent that they do not have all the resources themselves and that other members of the group have different resources than they do. This kind of activity is interesting and, depending on how it is used, can generate discussion about competition, sharing, and cooperation.

Johnson and Johnson (2012) describe a number of different kinds of group-decision activities. Two examples are (1) having members try to figure out the right supplies to take ("Winter Survival") and (2) having members try to complete a complicated puzzle through cooperation ("Hollow Squares exercise").

Touching Exercises

A number of exercises can involve touching. Some are done with the entire group, such as a group massage or milling and touching; others are done in pairs, such as members lightly touching each other's hands or faces. Touching can be a very comforting and supportive activity if done properly. Many trust exercises

involve touching in some manner. Also, some people are "touch deprived," and therefore, being touched can be a very helpful and freeing experience.

We cover touching exercises as a separate category because there are some cautions to consider when doing them. *Any leader using any exercise where touching is going to be involved must consider the appropriateness for and comfort of the members.* First, be aware that some members may not be comfortable with physical contact. If an exercise involves any form of touching, be sure everyone understands what will happen and then allow members to opt out of the exercise. Second, in almost all situations, it is best to avoid touching exercises that may have a sexual connotation. Some massage exercises, for example, may be interpreted as sexual unless properly conducted. With this exercise or any other that may be misinterpreted, the leader would want to be *very* careful to explain the exercise and its purpose and to allow members to choose not to participate. Exercises that tend to arouse sexual feelings usually serve no useful purpose, may frighten members, and may inappropriately arouse feelings between two members.

EXAMPLE

Leader: Because each of you is not used to positive comments or positive touch, I want to do an exercise that involves positive feedback as well as some nurturing touching on the shoulders. One at a time, each person is going to sit in this chair, and members are going to come up and gently touch your shoulders and say one or two positive comments about you. For many of you, hearing the positive comments will be uncomfortable as will be the touching. Some of you may find that touching the other person is uncomfortable. Let me demonstrate what would happen. John, come sit here. *(Leader gently rubs John's shoulders and says something positive.)* I want to encourage you to try this if at all possible, and then we can talk about what this was like to receive and give feedback. Does anyone have any questions or comments about how they are feeling about doing this? *(Pause)* If you want to go toward the last, let me know and that is fine. If you are not comfortable doing this, please let me know that as well. *(Pause)* Who is willing to be first in the chair?

Concluding Comments

Using exercises can be very beneficial, especially when the proper experiences are chosen. There are at least seven reasons for leaders to use exercises, including generating interest and energy, shifting the focus, deepening the focus, providing valuable information, providing an opportunity for experiential learning, increasing comfort, and providing fun and relaxation. A skilled leader understands why

and when to use exercises. We discuss 14 kinds of group exercises: written, movement, dyads and triads, rounds, creative props, arts and crafts, fantasy, common readings, feedback, trust, experiential, moral dilemmas, group decision, and touching. There are many good books on exercises for all kinds of groups. You will want to explore various sources that pertain to the population with which you are working.

ACTIVITIES

1. Think of a group and its purpose. Then list at least two creative, two movement, and two other exercises you could do with that group.
2. Think of three topics (such as anger, guilt, or divorce); then develop two written exercises that could be used to initiate discussion on each of the topics and two exercises that could be used to deepen the focus on each of the topics.



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS

1. View again videos 5.5 and 8.6, in which the leader uses sentence-completion exercises.
   a. How did the exercise help the leaders?
   b. How did the exercise help the members?
   c. How did the leader process the exercise? That is, how did the leader use the sentence completion in a way that it was interesting?

Throughout the DVD you will see many exercises conducted and processed. Always watch the way the exercise is introduced, conducted, and processed, which is the subject of the next chapter.